Conclusion

Two competing visions of Cuba seem to hold sway over the U.S. imagination. One is the Caribbean vision, of Cuba as a tourist destination, hot, colorful, beach-ringed, with plenty of music, drink, and sex. People in this Cuba are happy and carefree. The other is the Soviet vision, of Cuba as a dingy, gray, repressed police state, where citizens live in dreary fear.

Both visions are figments of a foreign imagination, Cubas invented by the worldviews of foreigners. The real Cuba is, like every country, diverse and complex. Its history over the past 50 years of the Revolution is also diverse and complex, and anything but static.

On my most recent visit to the island, in the summer of 2008, I was struck by three things in particular.

Since all of my personal experience in Cuba has been since the economic crisis that began in 1991, I always ask people "how is the situation?" This time the first answer people gave was about transportation: it's gotten much better. New Chinese buses were comfortable and reliable. It may seem trivial – but it has made a huge difference in daily life in Havana, a sprawling city in which almost everyone needs to commute.

On a more somber note, people hinted that both the health and the education systems, so long held up as the greatest successes of the Revolution, were faltering. As the state became less able to guarantee meaningful work, or even subsistence, to the more highly educated, both students and teachers were abandoning the goal of education and dropping out. A new program was trying to crash-train teachers and place them quickly in the schools, but their qualifications were weak, further undermining the system.

Health care too was suffering. Family doctors' offices were going unstaffed as tens of thousands of doctors were exported to Venezuela and elsewhere to bring back desperately needed foreign exchange. In April 2008, Raúl Castro announced reforms that would consolidate the